

3D for the web

Google recently released a piece of software called O3D that lets web applications use the computing power of the PC's graphics chip

Similar concepts

It turns out that Google's recently launched "similar images" lab feature was already a working feature with Microsoft's Live Search – since about four months back

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Agent 001 takes up a challenge to go a week without Google and its plethora of products**Agent 001**

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The other day I was having a casual conversation with my friend about – you guessed it – technology. The conversation quickly turned towards Google because it seems these days no commentary on anything remotely related to tech is ever complete without the G word creeping in. Now this gentleman I'm talking about is somewhat of the paranoid sort but well, who isn't? He thinks Big Brother is watching his every move and so he feebly tries to cover his tracks online, all the time. Even after repeated attempts of trying to convince him that his life is just not interesting enough to track, he doesn't seem to get the message. It's not surprising then, that he suffers from the "big company syndrome" wherein people start trusting a corporation less as it grows bigger; in this case – Google. Whether or not there is any merit in not trusting such an entity is debatable, but it's certainly worth some speculation. Imagine a single corporation such as Google, giving you access to so many services you so helplessly depend on, leading to much information that you unknowingly reveal to it. In an age where information is power, such an entity could have an awful lot of power, perhaps too much.

My friend then went on to tell me how dependent we are on Google and its many offerings and he'd bet that no

one can survive a week without using Google. Now this was interesting. I eagerly took him up on that challenge. Not because I find Google a Big Bad Wolf but because I'm quite bored of it. The same old layout for all the services – the top bar with settings and links to other services, the lame old blue and not to mention the overly simplistic presentation. This little experiment might turn out to be pretty interesting, I figured. A change is always nice, isn't it? Besides, any old hand would tell you that depending on a single supplier for all your needs is just bad practice.

Although I took it up gallantly, at the very outset it seemed likely that my "week without Google" could soon render me "weak without Google". Indeed we depend so much on the Mountain View giant. Its services that we all take for granted are varied and I admit, quite good. Even someone like me, who is generally a serious character, would like my daily dose of entertainment through YouTube. Not to mention the fact that, like many others, I depend heavily on Google Search, Gmail, Google Docs and Google maps. That's not all; I read somewhere that Google offers over seventy services, at least ten of which we've become habituated to use.

But I was determined to make it work. After all, no challenge is too big for Agent 001 right? The more I got down to breaking down Google's offerings and

looking for alternatives, it became apparent that there are equivalent, and sometimes even better options available out there. Here's what I found.

Search

Search is perhaps the single most important offering Google has. Well apart from mail of course, but I'll come back to that later. The problem of looking at alternatives for Google Search, however has got me thinking some more. It reminds me of a time back in January when it seemed Google search actually went offline for an hour. Well it didn't go offline in the traditional sense of the word – it just broke. That's right someone broke Google. For an hour Google kept identifying every search result as potentially harmful and didn't take you anywhere except a warning page. The problem was caused by human error. Some nitwit at one of Google's associates, [stopbadware.com](#), identified the back slash "/" as a bad site. The problem was solved on the double, but what if Google didn't come back on in an hour and had taken longer to fix? Makes one wonder about the repercussions, doesn't it? Would the economy slow down a little more? It's possible, many online shopping web sites would not get visitors. Transactions would dwindle down, and so on. So it appears that Google has become synonymous with the internet rather than being an access gate to the internet. If we were to draw a usage pie

representing the ways in which we use the Google Search engine, you'd be surprised to know that the maximum percentage would probably be as a spell checker. Followed by – searching for porn; searching for finding useful information; using it because you are unsure about the correct URL or even something as ridiculous as being lazy enough to type ".com". Pertaining to information we must remember that there are other entry points for accessing the vast amounts of information floating around in cyberspace.

Which other search engines can you use? I decided to visit my old favourite pre-Google era haunt [alltheweb.com](#). It's now owned by Yahoo!, it's still fast and the advanced search feature is quite extensive. I tried to put in a wrong spelling and it even offered me a "did you mean?" suggestion. Speaking of Yahoo, the Yahoo search itself is not that bad. Another option is Ask.com which has a nice simple interface; simpler than Google's. [Dogpile.com](#) is a search engine that aggregates results from other engines, while [Mamma.com](#) (aka. the mother of all search engines) is also an alternative. [Faganfinder.com](#) also helps me get to those really pesky bits of information on the web. The other biggie – Microsoft – provides a very viable alternative in its Live Search ([live.com](#)) service. It's good at searching the web, but at the same time I found it to be the best alternative when it comes to dethroning Google's image search. An image search